Teaching Statement

My goal when I teach is not just to deliver the course content, but to build students' confidence with it. Unlike other fields, economics is more than a set of knowledge to be mastered; it is a lens through which to see the world. Appealing to students' life experiences in the classroom both shows them the value in the content they are learning and helps translate their lived intuition into economic thinking. I always hope students continue their economics studies, but I know that even if their passion lies elsewhere, our field still has important lessons to give them. Over my nine quarters as a teaching assistant at UCSD I have taught five unique courses. These spanned principles of microeconomics and macroeconomics to intermediate courses and up through an advanced field elective, reaching 2,540 students across all sections. That range let me home in on my own teaching style and it revolves around two pillars: an interactive classroom that builds confidence, and a constant insistence that mastery is earned rather than innate.

An interactive classroom designed to build confidence

Interaction as a teaching philosophy is easy to prioritize because it so naturally finds its way into every part of an economics lecture. For example, when discussing willingness to pay, I share a story about how my old coworkers and I all wrote down how much we would be willing to pay for concert tickets. When teaching compensating and equivalent variation, I speak to Californians' recent memories of wildfires and the policy options on the table. Complementing economic theory with real-world examples gives students salient memories to hold onto when they are in the middle of an exam and trying to recall the exact definition they need.

When walking students through practice problems, this pillar looks like never stating the answer before the students get there themselves. I always ask students to help me highlight the relevant information in the question as a first step, and go the extra mile to have them physically underline those elements. Something I learned by being a Teaching Assistant was the virtue of patience. Earlier on in my tenure I would have trouble waiting through silence as they built up the confidence to answer back. I then ask students to take inventory of what information the question gives us, and what we instead need to "bring with us" to make good use of that information, like a formula or a fact. I have found that breaking up teaching in this fashion gives the students who are particularly overwhelmed something tangible to employ when they are working through a problem.

Mastery is earned: framing the student's job

The second pillar of my teaching philosophy is an insistence that mastery is earned rather than innate, and that most struggling students are just missing habits that they can acquire. Acting on that conviction means framing the job of being a student explicitly, especially for freshmen, who are learning far more than course content in my classroom. On average at UCSD, students arrived at college with relatively little supporting structure compared to what they had previously. I quickly learned that they found the self-discipline required to meet their newfound responsibilities challenging. I do what I can to help students navigate this transition, by setting clear expectations and guiding them toward good working habits. In the classroom, this looks like providing forward-guidance on how much studying is required to succeed, and explicitly providing guidelines for what will constitute effective studying. Most importantly though, this pillar manifests as explicitly telling students that it's never too late to learn the content even when exams are approaching.

One of the most rewarding experiences I had as a TA came from speaking with a student during a Principles of Microeconomics office hours, about a week before their second midterm. This student was not performing as well as they thought they should be given their effort, and was pessimistic about performing well on the next exam. After some conversation I learned that they had not been dedicating time to doing any timed practice exams, and thought that they had mastered the content

just by completing the homework assignments and practice exams at their own pace and checking their work ex-post. Their homework assignments were not evaluated with feedback, just graded on completion, so the first midterm was the only moment where this student had actually gotten any feedback from the instructor. I told the student that it wasn't too late to master the material but that they needed to do the practice exams while timing themselves and without any aids. That I needed to say this at all surprised me, but they were under the impression that just doing the required homework assignments was enough to succeed. The student thanked me as they handed in their exam, saying that our office hours chat was a turning point for them. They also said they would be changing their studying approach for their other classes going forward. Ensuring students know what's expected of them, and helping guide them through the transition to being full-time students will set up best practices for productivity even after they leave university.

I am ready to teach anywhere in the undergraduate core, and I thoroughly enjoy teaching principles classes where I get to buck stereotypes about our field and give students a strong first impression of economics. Beyond the core, I would like to build a course on risk and household decision-making in low-income settings, taught from data rather than from models alone: students would estimate moments from survey microdata, build portfolios, and see for themselves how much of what we call a preference turns out to be a constraint. Whatever the department needs covered, I want the students who take it to leave able to do something they could not do before, rather than only to recognize it on an exam. Not all of the teaching I am proudest of has happened in a classroom. In 2021 I helped found ECONnected, a UCSD initiative designed to connect undergraduates and graduate students to demystify the path into graduate studies in economics, which ran through 2023, and the mentoring relationships it produced are some of the work I am proudest of. I want students to leave my classroom more confident than they came in, and to know what it would take to reach the next level.

Teaching Evaluations:

The following table summarizes student evaluations for every course-quarter of my UC San Diego teaching appointments for which a report exists. UCSD replaced its Student IA Evaluation instrument with the Student Evaluation of Teaching (SET) in 2024. The two instruments ask different questions, so I report them separately below.

Summary of Student Evaluations

Student IA Evaluations (through 2023–24) Course	Quarter	Enrollment	Responses	Recommend to Others	Teaching Clarity	Section Usefulness
Principles of Microeconomics	Fall 2021	658	48	4.73	4.75	4.51
Principles of Macroeconomics	Winter 2022	501	43	4.65	4.78	4.64
Microeconomics A	Fall 2023	241	7	4.86	5.00	5.00
Principles of Microeconomics	Winter 2024	47	9	4.56	4.67	4.50
The Indian Economy	Spring 2024	182	3	4.67	4.50	4.00
Student Evaluations of Teaching (2024–25 onward) Course	Quarter	Enrollment	Responses	Effective Methods	Effective Communication	Supportive Environment
Microeconomics A	Fall 2024	532	30	4.37	4.37	4.34
Microeconomics C	Winter 2025	94	4	5.00	5.00	5.00
Principles of Microeconomics	Spring 2025	241	83	4.46	4.52	4.44
Microeconomics C	Fall 2025	44	10	4.70	4.90	4.90

Notes: Entries are mean responses on a 1–5 scale, where 5 is "Strongly Agree," pooled across the lecture sections I served that quarter. "No Opinion/Not Applicable" answers are excluded throughout, matching the university's scoring methodology. The IA items are recommending the instructional assistant to other students, presenting material clearly and answering questions accurately in section, and sections enhancing understanding of the material. The SET items are using instructional methods that helped the student learn and engage, communicating effectively, and creating a welcoming and supportive learning environment. Two section-quarters (Fall 2023 Microeconomics A section A00, one response, and Winter 2025 Microeconomics C section A00, two responses) are withheld by the university's three-response minimum to protect students' anonymity and so are absent from the table.

Selected Student Comments:

- "Vinny's Discussion Section was a huge help to me in this course. His lecture slides facilitated note taking while emphasizing important points, he gave us tips and areas to focus on, and did a good job working through hard and important practice problems with us. He always encouraged questions and participation and made his slides available after class. Thank you Vinny!"
- "Vinny is a great TA who clearly has a passion for this subject and also cares about his students. After the 2nd exam results, he was very active and decided to switch techniques in discussion in hopes of improving our exams scores. He was also available during office hours and emails. I am thankful on how fast Vinny could reply to my emails with valuable and helpful information."
- "Very good explanations for lectures like the Y2K problem and numerical outcomes examples like fertilizer share of rich to poor farmers."

Selected Faculty Comments:

- "Vinny was great in all his tasks. He put tremendous effort into his discussion section presentations. I was also very impressed with his comprehensive reviews of my draft exams, paying attention to many details as well as evaluating the exam from a big-picture point of view. As a result, we had fewer questions and clarification during exams than in any previous year." — Valerie Ramey, ECON 3
- "He made detailed slides for his discussion sections. He showed students the thought process involved in solving the problems. I think students who attended his sessions would be able to solve other problems using that thought process." — Herbert Newhouse, ECON 100A
- "Vinny has been a tremendous TA for this class, one whom I appreciate greatly and I believe students do too. [...] As an advanced graduate student and the only TA for the class, Vinny contributed meaningfully to discussions about the content direction of the class, and was very helpfully involved in writing homework, exam, and practice questions. [...] I believe Vinny will very capably teach his own classes in the near future, to the great benefit of students at UCSD or wherever he ends up next." — Jay Cizeski, ECON 100C
- "Vinny was part of the heart and soul of Econ 1 and helped make the course the success it was. [...] Thank you so much Vinny for your OUTSTANDING contributions to making Econ 1 a success this quarter!" — Melissa Famulari, ECON 1
- "Vinny is a fantastic TA and was a great partner teaching Econ 1 this quarter. [...] I particularly appreciate that Vinny created some Desmos demonstrations of math concepts to help the students brush up on the graphing and algebra skills they need for the class, [and] discussed his own research in discussion section to illustrate opportunity cost." — Melissa Famulari, ECON 1